

Culinary Basil Grow Guide

For Italian sweet basil, Genovese basil, Thai basil, lemon basil, cinnamon basil, purple basil, holy basil, and perennial basil types.

Sunlight - Soil - Watering - Feeding - Harvesting - Variety Identification - Problems - Transplanting

Best for	Home gardens, containers, kitchen gardens, raised beds, small farms, and fresh herb bundles.
Main use	Fresh leaves for seasoning, sauces, pesto, tea/herbal use depending on variety, garnishes, and market bunches.
Important note	Most soft culinary basil types have similar care, but they differ in flavor, scent, leaf shape, stem color, disease resistance, and how woody they become.

ParaLife Trees

Planting a Life in Paradise

1. Quick Rescue Page: If You See This, Do This

What You See	Most Likely Cause	What To Do First
Leaves droop but soil is dry	Underwatering / heat stress	Water deeply at soil level. Move potted basil to light shade for 24 hours.
Leaves droop but soil is wet	Root stress / poor drainage	Stop watering until top 1 inch dries. Check drainage holes and remove saucers of standing water.
Yellow patches with gray/purple fuzz under leaves	Basil downy mildew	Remove infected leaves/plants. Increase airflow. Keep leaves dry. Do not compost badly infected plants.
Lower leaves yellowing	Overwatering, low nitrogen, or old lower leaves	Check moisture first. If soil drains well, feed lightly. Remove yellow leaves.
Black/brown leaf spots	Leaf spot, wet foliage, or sun/water stress	Remove spotted leaves. Water soil, not leaves. Improve spacing and airflow.
Sticky leaves or curled new tips	Aphids, whiteflies, mealybugs	Check undersides and new shoots. Spray mild soap solution every 3-5 days if pests are present.
Fine webbing or speckled leaves	Spider mites	Rinse undersides of leaves. Avoid drought stress. Repeat treatment every 3-5 days.
Plant getting tall with flower spikes	Bolting / plant trying to flower	Pinch flower tips immediately. Harvest stems above a leaf pair.
Stem base black or plant collapses	Damping off / root rot	Remove collapsed plants. Improve drainage and airflow. <u>Avoid overwatering.</u>

For any serious problem, send photos of the full plant, leaf top, leaf underside, stem base, soil/pot, and any insects to WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415.

2. Quick Numbers Page

Item	Specific Range / Target
Crop type	Warm-season aromatic herb, mostly grown as an annual for fresh leaves
Best temperature	About 21-32°C / 70-90°F
Cold stress risk	Below about 10°C / 50°F
Sunlight	4-6+ hours daily; in very hot areas give morning sun and light afternoon shade
Soil pH	6.0-7.5
Plant spacing	12-18 inches for most culinary basil; 18-24 inches for larger perennial/shrub types
Container size	1-3 gallons for small basil; 3-5 gallons for larger bushy types
Transplant age from seed	4-6 weeks after sowing, once roots hold the cell and plant has several true leaves
Hardening-off period	5-7 days before full outdoor planting
First light harvest	When plant is about 6-8 inches tall and has 4-6 pairs of leaves
Main harvest window	About 60-90 days from seed for many basil types
Harvest frequency	Every 7-14 days during strong growth
Pinch flower tips	Check every 3-7 days once plants mature

This guide covers the care that is shared by most culinary basil types. Identification differences are listed in Section 3 so customers know what kind they are growing and what to expect.

3. Basil Types: Identification and Differences

Most basil types like warm weather, bright light, loose well-draining soil, and regular harvesting. The differences below help customers identify what they bought and how the flavor or growth habit may differ.

Basil Type	How To Identify It	Main Use / Difference
Italian Sweet Basil	Soft green leaves, sweet clove-like aroma, tender stems, broad oval leaves.	Good all-purpose cooking basil for sauces, salads, seasoning, and fresh use.
Genovese Basil	Large glossy cupped leaves, strong sweet basil aroma, classic pesto type.	Best known for pesto and Italian-style sauces. Often more sensitive to basil downy mildew than some specialty basil.
Thai Basil	Narrower leaves, firmer texture, purple stems, purple flower spikes, anise/licorice scent.	Holds flavor well in cooked dishes. Usually more heat-tolerant and sturdier than sweet basil.
Lemon Basil	Smaller to medium leaves, lemon/citrus scent, often lighter green and more delicate.	Good for teas, fish/vegetable seasoning, salads, and light sauces. Often shows more resistance to some basil disease issues than classic sweet basil.
Cinnamon Basil	Green leaves, purple stems/flowers, warm spicy cinnamon/clove scent.	Good for tea, desserts, infused drinks, and scented garden use.
Purple Basil / Dark Opal	Purple to burgundy leaves, decorative color, basil/clove scent.	Good for garnish, colored vinegar, salads, and ornamental edible planting. Color improves with strong light.
Holy Basil / Tulsi	More textured or slightly hairy leaves, spicy clove scent, can become woody and branchy.	Used more for tea/traditional herb use. Grows more shrub-like than soft Italian basil.
African Blue / Perennial Basil Types	Woody stems, larger bush, often purple flowers, strong scent, can live longer in warm climates.	Best for longer-term herb hedge/pollinator plant. Needs more pruning and more space.

4. Sunlight, Soil, and Water

Need	Target / Customer Instruction
Sunlight	Give 4-6+ hours daily. In hot Jamaican conditions, morning sun plus light afternoon shade works well.
Best location	Bright, warm spot with good airflow and protection from waterlogged soil.
Soil	Loose, rich, well-draining soil with compost. Avoid compacted soil that stays wet.
Soil pH	6.0-7.5
Watering	Water when the top 1 inch of soil begins to dry. Keep evenly moist, not soggy.
Containers	Use drainage holes. Do not let the pot sit in water. In hot weather, containers may need daily checking.
Mulch	Use light mulch to keep roots cooler and reduce soil splash. Keep mulch slightly away from the stem.

Water at soil level where possible. Wet leaves, crowding, and poor airflow increase fungal disease pressure, especially downy mildew and leaf spots.

5. Feeding Guide

Stage	Timing	Feeding Direction
At planting	Day 0	Mix compost into the soil. Avoid strong fertilizer directly against roots.
After settling	7-10 days after planting	Use light liquid feed or mild balanced fertilizer if leaves look pale.
Active growth	Every 2-4 weeks	Feed lightly. Basil grows best with steady nutrition, not heavy feeding.
Before harvest	Final 2-3 days before cutting	Focus on clean watering and healthy leaves. Avoid heavy fertilizer right before harvest.
Potted basil	Ongoing	Because nutrients wash out of pots faster, light feeding every 2-3 weeks may help.

Avoid overfeeding nitrogen. Too much soft leafy growth can attract pests and reduce strong flavor.

6. Harvesting Guide

Harvest Point	What To Do
First harvest	Start when plant is 6-8 inches tall and has 4-6 pairs of leaves.
How to cut	Cut just above a pair of leaves/nodes. This encourages two new shoots.
How much to remove	Do not remove more than about 1/3 of the plant at one time.
Harvest frequency	Harvest every 7-14 days during strong growth.
Best time	Early morning after dew dries, or late evening after heat drops.
Flower buds	Pinch flower buds every 3-7 days to keep the plant producing leaves.
Market bunches	Harvest clean stems, keep shaded, and avoid leaving harvested basil in hot sun.

For better branching, customers should not just pick single leaves from the bottom every time. Cutting stem tips above a leaf pair keeps basil bushier and more productive.

7. Leaf Color and Growth Problem Guide

Leaf / Growth Sign	Likely Cause	What To Do
Deep green, firm, aromatic leaves	Healthy growth	Continue regular harvesting and steady watering.
Pale green leaves	Low nitrogen, poor soil, or not enough light	Improve light and feed lightly.
Yellow lower leaves	Age, low nitrogen, or too much water	Remove yellow leaves. Check drainage before feeding.
Brown leaf edges	Heat stress, dry soil, fertilizer burn	Water evenly, reduce strong fertilizer, use light afternoon shade.
Black leaf patches after wet weather	Leaf spot or moisture stress	Remove affected leaves and keep foliage dry.
Tall weak stems	Low light or overcrowding	Move to brighter location and prune tips to encourage branching.
Woody stems	Normal with older holy/perennial basil or unpruned plants	Prune regularly; replace soft basil plants when quality declines.

8. Bolting and Flower Stalks

Basil naturally tries to flower as it matures. Flowering is not a disaster, but it can make leaf production slow down and leaf flavor stronger or harsher. Customers should pinch flower tips early if they want more leaves.

What You See	Meaning	What To Do
Small bud cluster at stem tip	Plant is starting to flower	Pinch or cut the tip above a leaf pair.
Long flower spikes	Plant is focusing on flowers/seeds	Cut back by 1/3 if plant is healthy. Water and feed lightly after pruning.
Bees visiting flowers	Normal, especially Thai, holy, and perennial basil	Leave some flowers if plant is for pollinators; cut flowers if plant is for leaf harvest.
Leaves getting smaller	Plant is older, stressed, or flowering	Prune tips, improve water/light, or restart with fresh seedlings.

9. Small Farmer Notes

Area	Recommendation
Spacing	Use 12-18 inches between plants for most basil; 18-24 inches for larger perennial basil types.
Batch planting	Plant new batches every 2-4 weeks for steady sales and fresh bundles.
Harvest rotation	Cut from different rows or sections every 7-14 days. Do not strip plants bare.
Disease prevention	Avoid overhead watering late in the day. Increase row airflow. Do not harvest wet plants.
Market handling	Keep harvested basil shaded. Basil bruises and wilts quickly in hot sun.
Sanitation	Use clean scissors/knife. Remove diseased plants early. Do not compost severe downy mildew plants near production.

10. Home Garden Notes

Customer Type	Simple Instruction
2-6 plants in pots	Use 1-3 gallon pots, drainage holes, morning sun, and regular tip harvesting.
Kitchen garden bed	Space 12-18 inches apart. Plant close enough for easy harvest but not so close that leaves stay wet.
Balcony / veranda	Give bright light. Rotate pots weekly. Watch moisture because pots dry faster.
Tea/herbal use	Holy basil, lemon basil, cinnamon basil, and some perennial types are especially useful for teas and scented harvests.
Pesto/sauce use	Genovese and Italian sweet basil are the main choices for classic pesto and sauces.

11. Clean Handling and Seedling Sanitation

Clean handling matters because basil leaves are eaten fresh and diseases spread easily through wet leaves, dirty tools, infected plant material, and crowded growing areas.

Sanitation Step	Why It Matters
Wash hands before handling plants	Reduces spread of plant diseases and keeps harvest cleaner.
Use clean scissors or knife	Reduces transfer of disease between plants.
Do not harvest wet plants	Wet leaves bruise easily and spread fungal spores faster.
Remove diseased leaves/plants	Reduces spores and keeps problems from spreading.
Keep trays and pots off dirty ground	Reduces soil splash and root disease.
Do not smoke over seedlings or rest cigarettes on trays	Good nursery hygiene; also important around vegetable/herb seedlings generally.

12. Hardening Off Seedlings

This section is mainly for customers buying seedlings from trays or small pots. Potted plants already growing outdoors may need less hardening off, but tray seedlings should still be protected from sudden hot sun.

Day	Exposure
Day 1-2	Bright shade for 2-3 hours. Keep cells moist.
Day 3-4	Morning sun for 2-4 hours, then shade.
Day 5-6	Morning sun plus bright afternoon shade. Watch for wilting.
Day 7	Ready to plant early morning or late evening

Do not move basil seedlings straight from shade or nursery protection into full hot sun for the whole day. Sudden sun and dry roots can stunt or kill soft seedlings.

13. Transplanting From Trays or Small Pots

Step	Instruction
1	Water the seedlings 1-2 hours before transplanting.
2	Prepare the hole or container before removing the plant.
3	Remove seedling gently and keep the root ball together.
4	Plant at the same soil level as the tray/pot. Do not bury leaves.
5	Press soil gently around roots and water immediately.
6	Give light shade for 1-2 days if the sun is harsh.
7	Check daily for the first 3-5 days.

14. Common Pests

Pest	Signs	Action
Aphids	Soft insects on new tips, curled leaves, sticky honeydew.	Spray off with water or mild soap solution. Repeat every 3-5 days.
Whiteflies	Tiny white insects fly when disturbed; yellowing/sticky leaves.	Spray undersides, use sticky traps, remove infested leaves.
Mealybugs	White cottony clusters on stems or leaf joints.	Wipe off small groups; spray mild soap solution.
Spider mites	Fine webbing, speckled/dusty leaves, worse in dry heat.	Rinse undersides, reduce drought stress, repeat treatment.
Caterpillars	Chewed holes, droppings, missing leaf edges.	Handpick early morning/evening; remove damaged leaves.
Leafminers	White winding tunnels inside leaves.	Remove affected leaves and control weeds nearby.

15. Common Diseases

Disease	Signs	Action
Basil downy mildew	Yellow patches on top of leaves; gray/purple fuzzy growth under leaves.	Remove infected plants/leaves. Keep leaves dry. Improve airflow and spacing.
Fusarium wilt	Sweet basil may grow normally until 8-12 inches, then wilt, stunt, and show stem discoloration.	Remove infected plants. Do not reuse contaminated soil for basil. Use resistant varieties when possible.
Leaf spot	Brown/black spots, often worse with wet leaves and poor airflow.	Remove affected leaves. Water soil, not leaves. Improve spacing.
Root rot	Wilting with wet soil, weak plant, dark roots, bad soil smell.	Reduce watering. Improve drainage. Repot if container soil stays soggy.
Damping off	Young seedlings collapse at soil line.	Use clean trays/media. Avoid overwatering and overcrowding.
Gray mold / Botrytis	Soft gray fuzzy mold on damaged or wet plant tissue.	Remove affected tissue. Improve airflow and avoid wet foliage.

16. ParaLife Trees Support Page

Need help with your basil plant?

Send clear photos of:

Photo Needed	Purpose
Full plant	Shows overall size, shape, wilting, and spacing.
Top of leaves	Shows color, spots, yellowing, and sun damage.
Underside of leaves	Shows downy mildew, whiteflies, aphids, mites, and eggs.
Stem base and soil/pot	Shows root rot, drainage, and transplant problems.
Any insects or damaged leaves	Helps identify pest problems quickly.

WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415

Sources used for general crop guidance: University of Maryland Extension, UC IPM, University of Delaware Cooperative Extension, UF/IFAS Extension, Iowa State Extension, UMass Extension, and RHS basil growing guidance.

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